

TEACH

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHY

FOR WHAT-HOW · HOW-WHAT

The Opening Line Habit

A micro-practice: every email, deck, and deliverable opens with one sentence of purpose before any content. **Small, trainable, and disproportionate in effect.**

THE DRAIN

Purpose framing drains WHAT-HOW and HOW-WHAT profiles at every scale, including the smallest: the email that starts mid-process, the deck that opens on data, the update that assumes the reader remembers why. Each costs the reader orientation, and collectively they cost the writer a reputation for meaning.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The habit shrinks the purpose burden to a single trained sentence. One line, from a small set of learnable openers, placed before the content in everything you send. It is the minimum effective dose of WHY work: fifteen seconds of drain that saves every reader minutes and reframes how your thinking is perceived.

The openers

- 1 "This matters because...", the direct form, works almost everywhere.
- 2 "The decision this enables is...", strongest for executive readers.
- 3 "By the end of this you'll know...", best for documents and presentations.
- 4 "We're doing this so that...", best for instructions and requests.
- 5 "Nothing needed from you; this is so that...", the FYI form, prevents mis-escalation.

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Pick two openers and drill them.** Habit needs a small menu. Two forms cover ninety percent of what you send.
- 2 **Write the line last, place it first.** After the content exists, the purpose line takes fifteen seconds. Before, it takes real energy.
- 3 **Apply it to everything for two weeks.** Including trivial messages. The habit forms on volume, not on importance.
- 4 **Watch the replies change.** Fewer clarifying questions, faster responses. The feedback loop is what locks the habit in.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

One sentence is orientation, not strategy; documents with real stakes still need the Brief or the Arc behind them. And the habit will feel mechanical at first, that is what training a tertiary micro-skill feels like, and mechanical done consistently beats inspired done never.

IN THE KIT

Opener reference card

Two-week habit tracker

Before/after inbox examples

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 24 The So-What Translator · **Tool 21** Five-Question Purpose Brief · **Tool 18** Progress Broadcast Template